DSEH004 Performance Management and Employee Engagement

Week 9 | Lecture 3 | Unit III to Unit IV bridge

Sponsorship and Equitable Advancement

Mentors advise, sponsors advocate: networks, the broken rung and fair promotion systems

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Commit before theory

Two equally rated analysts apply for promotion. One has a senior leader who speaks for her in the promotion meeting. Who usually wins, and why does it matter?

A The better performer, because ratings decide

B The one with an advocate, because decisions are social

C It is random

D The one with longer tenure

Mentor and sponsor

Mentor

- Advises, listens, builds confidence
- Kram (1985): career and psychosocial functions
- Relationship can stay private

vs

Sponsor

- Advocates in rooms you are not in
- Spends personal reputation on your behalf
- Hewlett (2013): sponsorship drives advancement

Ibarra, Carter and Silva (2010): women were often mentored but less often sponsored

Why networks shape careers

1 Weak ties

Granovetter (1973): acquaintances bring new information that close friends do not

2 Structural holes

Burt (1992): people who bridge separate groups gain advantage

3 Social resources

Seibert, Kraimer and Liden (2001): networks give information, resources and sponsorship that predict career success

The broken rung



McKinsey and LeanIn.Org (2019): the biggest obstacle for women was the first step up to manager, not the glass ceiling

Making advancement fair

Design move	Mechanism	Evidence base
Clear criteria before review	Reduces room for shifting standards	Castilla (2015)
Accountability for decisions	Decision makers must justify outcomes	Castilla (2015)
Formal sponsorship	Extends advocacy beyond informal networks	Hewlett (2013); Ibarra et al. (2010)
Outcome audits by group	Detects reward-stage bias	Castilla (2008)
Avoid meritocracy slogans alone	Can license bias	Castilla and Benard (2010)

Promotion committee at a consulting firm

Teaching case (Course framing)

A Delhi consulting firm promotes analysts to consultant through a committee of partners. Analysts with a partner speaking for them are promoted at twice the rate of others with similar ratings. Women and analysts from non-metro colleges are less likely to have such a partner.

Work it through

1. Explain the pattern with network theory
2. Is sponsorship the problem or the solution?
3. Which fairness design moves would you introduce first?
4. How would you know whether they worked?

Exam-style question

Distinguish mentoring from sponsorship and explain, using network theory, why sponsorship affects advancement. How can an organization make advancement more equitable? (20 marks)

What a strong answer does

- Uses Kram's functions and Hewlett's distinction
- Applies Granovetter, Burt and Seibert et al.
- Explains the broken rung with appropriate caution about the source
- Proposes designs grounded in Castilla's findings

Sources (1 of 2)

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